take my eyes off her. And I could see Victoria was looking back at me. *I should be trying to get her number, at least trying to say something else to her*. But I didn't. She left. I left. That was it; I'd blown my big chance. I got back on the team bus and it was all I could do not to start banging my head against the back of the seat in front in frustration.

During the course of the following week, once I'd got over feeling sorry for myself, I found out a little more about the Girl of my dreams. Despite the missed opportunity, meeting her had only made me more certain about her. I saw the piece in *90 Minutes* magazine featuring the Spice Girls in their soccer uniforms, Victoria in United colors and a caption saying she liked the look of David Beckham. I didn't know how these things worked; that the quote from her might have just been made up. No: made up was what I was. And for the next home game, there she was at Old Trafford.

This time, it had been the full works. Victoria had been wined and dined before the match by Martin Edwards, the United Chairman. She and Melanie had gone out on the field to do the half-time scores. And now she was in the players' lounge after the game, in the middle of another glass of champagne. I walked in and went over to say hello to Mum and Dad. And, because we'd met before—briefly, nervously—it was easier this time to say hello to Victoria. She looked fantastic in tight combat trousers and a little khaki top, cut quite low; an unbelievable figure. I remember hoping she wouldn't get the wrong idea about me and her cleavage: there was a tiny blemish, like a freckle, at the top of her breastbone that I just couldn't stop staring at.

Deciding what to say next wasn't exactly obvious. *This is it. You're the one*. That was in my head. But you can't really make that sort of declaration to someone you've only ever said three words to, especially with your mum and dad and your team-mates within earshot. Joanne was there and she and Victoria seemed to be doing better on the small talk than I was. My sister, at least, had some idea of how I was feeling. I did the bloke thing and went off to the bar to get a round of drinks. The next moment, Victoria was there beside me. It wasn't like we knew what we wanted to say. How do you start? What's it like being a pop star? What's it like playing soccer for a living? But I think we both knew that we needed to be speaking to each other and once we started talking—at last—neither of us wanted to stop. Next time I was aware of where I was, I was looking around the room and thinking: *Where's everybody gone?*

Mum and Dad were still there. *Oh, no. Not a Spice Girl* they were probably muttering to themselves. And one or two other people were just sort